



reclaim the shrine. It is Vijay's secular duty to stop the storming. The triumph of *The Solitude of Emperors* is that it is a political novel illuminated by the personal, and Davidar never lets his narrative fall into the trap of dead certainties. In Meham, marked by its fuchsia gardens and gentlemen's clubs, Vijay is an intruder who will soon get access to its secrets, and he alone knows that the idyll is going to be shattered. The name of his epiphany is Noah, and this man whose past is as mysterious as the hills, is the fourth emperor whose solitude brings a rare poignancy to the narrative in the end.

Noah, in his Jimi Hendrix T-shirt, is the prophet outcast of the hills, who lives in a cemetery, and whose companions are the dog named Godless and poets like Pessoa, Rimbaud and Moraes. His back story begins in Meham and stretches to Bombay and beyond, and it continues to retain a sense of the unknown. Noah journeys to where romantics like Vijay only dream about, and gives death a

God, Ashoka, Akbar and Gandhi—the emperors of renunciation, faith and truth respectively—tell him about a higher god: the emperor of the everyday. He is the chosen one, the idealistic young.

This novel, though, is more intelligent than its narrator. Its idealism doesn't verge on naivety. "I am certainly a secular idealist," says Davidar, "but I do have a deep interest in religion, all major faiths. At the same time I have a problem with the uncritical acceptance of faith, scripture and religious teaching. And I am most disturbed by the cynical misuse of religion." In *The Solitude of Emperors* is dissent at its literary best. Davidar does not hesitate to call it a political novel. "This is an overtly political novel in the tradition of novelists I greatly admire, such as Orwell, Coetzee and Pamuk. Indeed I think it would be almost impossible for a serious novelist today to be apolitical." Some of the finest storytellers at work today are trapped in history. And in their stories,

EXCERPTS

They are the invisible ones, the ones who were too small, weak, poor or slow to escape the onrush of history. No obituaries mark their passing, no memorials honour their name and we don't remember them because in our eyes they never existed. Yet we ignore them at our peril, if only because their fate today could be ours tomorrow; history is an insatiable tyrant.

I have never been much good at ritual or ceremonial homage—I blame this on my parents, who never really taught me—so I have had to invent a private rite of remembrance for Noah, a man who was ignored by almost everyone for as long as he lived, but who, in his death, affected me more powerfully than I would have thought possible. I can picture his mocking smile now, for the ceremony I'm about to conduct takes its inspiration from a somewhat bizarre funeral I saw him preside over all those many years ago. It is the middle of winter in this northern city, and even though the bitter cold would deter most from setting foot outside a heated room, I have always been stubborn and determined once I have decided to do something, and so I shuffle through the wind and snow to the cemetery closest to my house.

Once there, I look for a grave with an angel on its headstone there is a crust of snow on the grave and I scrape it off, unroll the plastic mat I have brought with me, and sit down. Noah wouldn't have liked this cemetery, it's too neat and formal; he believed the dead were entitled to comfortable lived-in surroundings.

ers. Sorabjee's written words, in their searing simplicity, whisper wisdom to Vijay as he gets initiated into the private history of the hills.

He, the secular idealist, wants to be the saviour of the Tower of God, a hilltop shrine of Christian mysticism, though with its own mythology of conquest and vandalism. A local Hindu party, led by a leader schooled in the Bombay riots, is leading an agitation to

meaning that is more than strait-jacketed heroism. Set against the solitude of Noah and the idealism of Vijay is the politics of the one-dimensional Rajan, the leader who wants to liberate the shrine. Made out of yesterday's headlines, he is a stereotype, a man with a history of hurt, seeking justice in retrospect. He thinks the gods are on his side. As Vijay gets deeper into the sorrows and fears of the Tower of

history is not a distant place; and their stories are hardly historical. History is an adjective to existence, as in Davidar's sprawling first novel, *The House of Blue Mangoes*. *The Solitude of Emperors* is the memorial service of a novelist for whom storytelling is what Vaclav Havel calls "living in truth". Davidar's story is an argument that redeems an India ravaged by the extremities of religion ■